GONE WITH THE WIND

'Team Rahul Gandhi', the band of young leaders touted as the Congress scion's able lieutenants, lies in disarray. Several of them have quit the party, others sulk openly

BY KAUSHIK DEKA



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A week after the Congress's humiliating defeat in the 2014 Lok Sabha election, one of the party's young Turks who also happened to have been a minister in both regimes of the United Progressive Alliance (UPA), told INDIA TODAY: "Now Pappu will understand what it means to be in politics. It's not easy surviving in the Opposition camp." Pappu, of course, is a derogatory reference to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, popularised in social media by his detractors.

The comment was later withheld at the leader's request, but it was one of the first indicators of disgruntlement among the younger lot who had come to the fore after Rahul joined politics in 2004. While the Gandhi scion has 'survived'—even helmed the party at one point despite the multiple electoral debacles since that disastrous summer of 2014—several leaders of his generation, including the minister who had made the aforementioned comment, have deserted Rahul and the party.

On January 25, R.P.N Singh became only the latest member of 'Team Rahul' to desert the Congress ship. This ambitious coterie took shape in July 2003 at a three-day *chintan shivir* (brainstorming session) of the Congress in Shimla. At the *shivir*, a Congress general secretary known for his proximity to the Gandhi family, had gone around asking the participants to name young Congressmen who could be groomed as future leaders. On the final day of the session, on July 9, a few names were scribbled on a piece of paper—Sachin Pilot, Jyotiraditya Scindia, Jitin Prasada and R.P.N. Singh. They were expected to work closely with Rahul, and all of them, besides two others—Ajay Maken and Manish Tewari—were given tickets to contest the Lok Sabha election in 2004 in which Rahul too made his debut. Five years later, two more names—Jitendra Singh and Milind Deora—were added to the list made up mostly of scions of political dynasties.

RAHUL NO LONGER RELIES ON THE COUNSEL OF ANY PARTICULAR LEADER AND HAS ADOPTED WHAT ONE LEADER CALLS A HORSES-FOR-COURSES APPROACH

Nearly two decades later, his team—all of whom have served as Union ministers—has disintegrated. Three of them—Scindia, Prasada and RPN—have joined the BJP. Pilot and Deora have expressed discontent on many occasions. Tewari, one of the Group of 23 leaders who had written a letter to Congress president Sonia